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Sports and Identity Analysis

Part 1: Research Intersection

My topic is how sports broadcasters describe Black and white football players differently, usually calling white players smart and Black players athletic. This is interesting because it happens on every broadcast and most people don't notice it.

Part 2: Popular Press Research

An NPR article with professor Pat Ferrucci explains that white athletes usually get called intelligent or good leaders, while Black athletes get called physically gifted, and Asian athletes get called smart team players (NPR, 2019). A WBUR article talks to journalist Derrick Z. Jackson about how this language affects who gets hired as coaches later since white players are already seen as the smart ones (WBUR, 2020). An Andscape article covers a study that used AI to scan broadcast transcripts and found the same bias, plus found that white players get called by their last name more often than Black players (Andscape, 2020). All three articles agree on the same basic pattern even though they come at it in different ways.

Part 3: Visual Media

I watched ESPN's *Year of the Black Quarterback* special. It covers the history of Black quarterbacks not being allowed to play the position for a long time. Warren Moon talks about how quarterback, center, and linebacker were positions Black players weren't allowed to play because those were seen as the "thinking" positions. This connects to the broadcaster language issue because it shows the bias used to be an actual rule, not just word choice.

Part 4: Academic Research

A 2019 study by Merullo and other researchers looked at over 1,400 football broadcasts and used computer models to check for bias in how announcers talked about 250,000 player

mentions, and found white players got more smart/leader words and nonwhite players got more athletic words even after controlling for position (Merullo et al., 2019). Another study interviewed sports media workers in the Netherlands and found most of them said racial stereotyping happens in sports media in general but almost none said they personally do it (Van Sterkenburg et al., 2021). A third study watched English football fans while they watched games and found they repeated the same racialized language as the commentators (Van Sterkenburg & Walder, 2024). These studies cover the broadcasters, the workers making the broadcasts, and the fans watching them.

Part 5: Personal Conversations

I talked to three people about this topic after sending them the NPR and Andscape articles. Tyler, my roommate who played wide receiver in high school, said coaches called him explosive but called a worse white quarterback on his team smart. My aunt, who teaches middle school, said teachers do the same thing with students, not just athletes. A family friend who coaches club volleyball said almost all the research is about men's sports and asked if the same thing happens in women's sports commentary, which nobody seems to have studied yet.

- Tyler, roommate, former high school wide receiver
- My aunt, middle school teacher
- Family friend, club volleyball coach

Part 6: Summary

This topic is about how football broadcasters describe Black and white players differently, calling white players smart and Black players athletic even when they do the same things on the field. It matters because this affects who gets hired for coaching and front office jobs later since the "smart" players are seen as more qualified. It's interesting because it's not one broadcaster being obviously biased, it's a pattern across decades of broadcasts that a computer study confirmed by checking a quarter million player mentions. The effects go beyond football since people I talked to noticed the same pattern in schools, meaning this might be a bigger issue than just sports.